

Blind Spot Autobiography Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and the Knower • 20 min

Category	Knowledge and the Knower	Time	20 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	blind-spot-autobiography

Big idea: Self-knowledge includes awareness of limits.

Overview

Students reflect on the limits of their own knowing without forced disclosure.

Student Prompt

Inspect Blind Spot Autobiography Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Blind Spot Autobiography Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A private reflection on one belief students changed without sharing sensitive content. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Blind Spot Autobiography Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: A 'known unknowns' box for topics students realise they rarely question. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Blind Spot Autobiography Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A perspective inventory naming communities that make some assumptions feel obvious. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Self-knowledge includes awareness of limits.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Blind Spot Autobiography Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Blind Spot Autobiography Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Can knowing your bias make you less biased?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how self-knowledge includes awareness of limits.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: A private reflection on one belief students changed without sharing sensitive content.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- A private reflection on one belief students changed without sharing sensitive content.
- A 'known unknowns' box for topics students realise they rarely question.
- A perspective inventory naming communities that make some assumptions feel obvious.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Students privately complete three prompts: "Something I used to believe", "Something I strongly believe but cannot fully prove", and "Something I may be biased about".	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	Students choose one safe example to discuss with a partner, or keep all examples private.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	The class builds a list of causes of blind spots: identity, language, friendship group, schooling, emotion, incentives and media.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Finish with a one-sentence reflection: "A good knower should..."	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may treat perception or memory as a recording device.
- Students may assume confidence is evidence rather than a feeling about evidence.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Separates perception, memory, belief, confidence, and justification.
- Uses the activity result to make a cautious claim about knowers.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Short lesson: use only the first example, one response grid, and one debrief question.
- Long lesson: add a second round where students revise the method and compare outcomes.
- Low-tech option: run with printed cards, sticky notes, and a board tally.

Extension Tasks

- Design a second version of the activity that tests the same knowledge issue in another AOK.
- Find a real-world example where the same knowledge problem matters outside the classroom.
- Write a 150-word TOK exhibition-style commentary using the activity as the object context.

Related Activities

- Change Blindness Starter
- Confidence Calibration Test
- Personal Knowledge Map